machine on. All the detergent had made it overflow and there was foam everywhere.

That was the first and last time I did the laundry on my own. Every other time Solly bhai's family kindly came to my rescue. Solly Adams, who I fondly referred to as Solly bhai, was a resident of Dewsbury in West Yorkshire. I had first met Solly and his wife Mariam in 1990 in the company of Dilip Vengsarkar. Every Mumbai cricketer who had played league cricket in England had spoken to me about Solly bhai's hospitality and it was natural that I should get in touch with him. His house had become a refuge for all Indian cricketers in the area and we all looked forward to the delectable food we were served at Solly bhai's house, particularly the biryani, tandoori chicken, raita and mango lassi. It soon became a ritual for me to visit him three times a week when I was in Yorkshire.

Solly bhai's brother Younus and his wife Ruksana were also great hosts and it was from them that I learnt the art of filling the salad bowl. When a few of my friends – Jatin Paranjpe, Mufi and Vinod Kambli – came to stay with me in Yorkshire, we mostly survived on cheap fast food. As the only member of the quartet who was earning, I would pay the bills and, with limited resources, fast food was the most affordable option. We would eat out at KFC, Burger King and the like, but the all-you-can-eat buffet at Pizza Hut was our favourite. While we could eat as many pizzas as we wanted for a fixed price, we could only fill up our salad bowl once. And it was here that the training from Younus and Ruksana came in handy. They taught me to use lettuce leaves to construct a wall, so that the size of the bowl, which was ordinarily just two or three inches tall, increased to five or six inches. We could then fill it with as much salad as we wanted.

I finally left Yorkshire for India around mid-August, to get back in time for the Duleep Trophy, India's second most important domestic competition. It's named after Ranjitsinhji's nephew Duleepsinhji, who played for England in the early 1930s, and features teams representing the country's five zones: West, North, South, East and Central, It was suggested that I should play in it before we left for what would be a challenging tour of South Africa in October. The Yorkshire management was most considerate and allowed me to come back early, thus ending a really fruitful and productive time in county cricket.